Meditations on Gandhi, Indianness and Politics

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In the Indian tradition, a yatra—loosely translated to a journey or pilgrimage—has immense social and spiritual value. Most of our ancient holy sites are located atop remote mountains, because it is believed that only by embracing solitude and suffering can a person transcend the everyday life, which is dictated by the need to address immediate concerns. Therefore, it is not a coincidence that all the great prophets of India were yatris—whether it was Gautam Buddha, Guru Nanak or Shankaracharya. And yatras were central to their life stories.

Mahatma Gandhi's first major political act upon his return to India was to journey through the entire nation like a commoner. This experience transformed him, but, more importantly, it transformed the Congress party from a debating club of the elite to an organization capable of launching sustained campaigns of non-violent mass action that eventually led to the liquidation of the British Empire. A yatra provides two very important things. For the spiritual seeker, it provides the time and space to reflect, meditate and see the bigger picture, thereby revealing simple yet profound truths that would otherwise evade them; for the political actor, it helps them connect with the common masses and develop an experience-based critique of the ruling sociopolitical orthodoxies of their time.

The Bharat Jodo Yatra provided me with the time to reflect upon politics and life. The opportunity to meet thousands of people across the length of the country and experience their cultures enriched my understanding of India, Indianness and the Congress.